himself to his good people of Lahore with a Moslem public woman, indulging in the least innocent of sports with her on the back of an elephant . . .'[66]

Burnes was just as taken with Ranjit Singh as Jacquemont had been, and the two quickly became firm friends: 'Nothing could exceed the affability of the Maharajah,' he wrote. 'He kept up an uninterrupted flow of conversation for the hour and a half which the interview lasted: he enquired particularly about the depth of water in the Indus and the possibility of navigating it.' The dray horses and the carriage were then inspected: 'The sight of the horses excited his utmost wonder; their size and colour pleased him: he said they were little elephants, and as they passed singly before him, he called out to the different sardars and officers, who joined in his admiration.'[67] Indeed such was Ranjit's pleasure in his gifts, and Lord Ellenborough's letter which accompanied them, that he ordered an unprecedented artillery salute of sixty guns, each firing twenty-one times, so that the people of Lahore would be in no doubt as to his enthusiasm for his new English alliance.

For two months, Ranjit laid on a round of entertainments for Burnes. Dancing girls performed, troops were manoeuvred, deer were hunted, monuments were visited and banquets were thrown. Burnes even tried some of Ranjit's home-made hell-brew, a fiery distillation of raw spirit, crushed pearls, musk, opium, gravy and spices, two glasses of which was normally enough to knock out the most hardened British drinker, but which Ranjit recommended to Burnes as a cure for his dysentery. Burnes and Ranjit, the Scot and the Sikh, found themselves bonding over a shared taste for fire-water. 'Runjeet Singh is, in every respect, an extraordinary character,' wrote Burnes. 'I have heard his French officers observe that he has no equal from Constantinople to India.'[68]

At their final dinner, Ranjit agreed to show Burnes the Koh-i-Nur. 'Nothing', wrote Burnes, 'can be imagined more superb than this stone; it is of the finest water, about half the size of an egg. Its weight amounts to 3½ rupees, and if such a jewel is to be valued, I am informed it is worth 3½ millions of money.'[69]

Ranjit then presented Burnes with two richly caparisoned horses, dressed in costly Kashmiri shawls, their necks adorned with necklaces of agate and with heron plumes rising from between their ears. While Burnes thanked Ranjit for the present, one of the dray horses was paraded for a final